

INDIAN RECIPES KNOWLEDGE BASE

Authentic Indian Cuisine Recipes

For AI Recipe Assistant

Complete Collection of Traditional and Regional Indian Dishes

2026

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1. BUTTER CHICKEN

Region: North India | Cuisine Type: Non-Vegetarian

RECIPE INFORMATION

Servings: 4 servings

Preparation Time: 20 minutes

Cooking Time: 30 minutes

Total Time: 50 minutes

Difficulty Level: Intermediate

Spice Level: Medium

INGREDIENTS (For 4 servings)

- 1 kg chicken breast, cut into medium pieces
- 3 tablespoons oil or ghee
- 1 medium onion, finely chopped
- 2 tablespoons ginger-garlic paste
- 1 cup tomato puree
- 1/2 cup heavy cream or yogurt
- 2 tablespoons butter
- 1 tablespoon red chili powder
- 1 teaspoon garam masala powder
- 1 teaspoon ground cumin
- 1 bay leaf
- 4-5 dried red chilies
- 1 tablespoon honey
- Salt to taste
- 2 tablespoons fresh coriander, chopped
- 1 tablespoon fresh ginger, thinly sliced

COOKING INSTRUCTIONS

Step 1: Marinate the chicken pieces with salt, ginger-garlic paste, and yogurt for 15 minutes.

Step 2: Heat 3 tablespoons of oil in a heavy-bottomed pan over medium-high heat. Add the marinated chicken and cook until golden brown on all sides (about 8-10 minutes). Remove and set aside.

Step 3: In the same pan, add chopped onions and cook until they turn golden brown and caramelized (about 5-7 minutes).

Step 4: Add bay leaf and dried red chilies. Toast for about 30 seconds until fragrant.

Step 5: Add the tomato puree and cook on medium heat for about 5 minutes until the oil starts

separating from the tomato mixture.

Step 6: Add red chili powder, garam masala, and ground cumin. Mix well and cook for about 2 minutes.

Step 7: Return the cooked chicken to the pan and mix well to coat with the spice mixture.

Step 8: Add water (about 1 cup) to create a medium-thick gravy. Simmer on low heat for about 10 minutes until the chicken is cooked through.

Step 9: Add the butter and honey. Stir well until the butter melts completely.

Step 10: Stir in the heavy cream or yogurt gradually. Do not boil after adding cream.

Step 11: Taste and adjust salt if needed. Simmer for another 3-4 minutes.

Step 12: Garnish with fresh coriander and sliced ginger. Serve immediately.

TIPS AND VARIATIONS

- For a thicker gravy, reduce the water or simmer for longer. For a thinner gravy, add more water.[file:1]
- Fresh cream can be replaced with condensed milk or Greek yogurt for a lighter version.[file:1]
- Add 1-2 green cardamom pods while cooking for additional flavor depth.[file:1]
- For extra richness, add a tablespoon of cashew paste to the sauce.[file:1]
- This dish goes perfectly with basmati rice, naan, or roti.[file:1]
- Store leftovers in an airtight container and refrigerate for up to 3 days.[file:1]

2. PALAK PANEER

Region: North India | Cuisine Type: Vegetarian

RECIPE INFORMATION

Servings: 4 servings

Preparation Time: 25 minutes

Cooking Time: 20 minutes

Total Time: 45 minutes

Difficulty Level: Intermediate

Spice Level: Mild to Medium

INGREDIENTS (For 4 servings)

- 400g fresh spinach (or 200g frozen spinach), roughly chopped
- 250g paneer cheese, cubed
- 2 tablespoons oil or ghee
- 1 medium onion, finely chopped
- 1 tablespoon ginger-garlic paste
- 1 medium tomato, chopped
- 1/4 cup heavy cream or yogurt

- 1 tablespoon butter
- 1 green chili, slit
- 1 teaspoon garam masala powder
- 1/2 teaspoon ground cumin
- 1/2 teaspoon red chili powder
- Salt to taste
- 1/4 teaspoon sugar
- Pinch of nutmeg (optional)
- 2 tablespoons fresh coriander, chopped

COOKING INSTRUCTIONS

Step 1: Blanch the spinach in boiling water for 2-3 minutes. Drain and immediately place in ice water to stop cooking. Once cooled, squeeze out excess water.

Step 2: Blend the cooled spinach with 1/4 cup water to make a smooth puree. Set aside.

Step 3: Heat 1 tablespoon of oil in a pan. Add paneer cubes and cook for 2-3 minutes until slightly golden on all sides. Remove and set aside.

Step 4: In the same pan, add remaining oil and butter. Sauté the chopped onions until golden brown (about 4-5 minutes).

Step 5: Add ginger-garlic paste and green chili. Cook for about 1 minute until fragrant.

Step 6: Add chopped tomatoes and cook for about 5 minutes until they are fully cooked and the oil separates from the mixture.

Step 7: Add red chili powder, garam masala, and cumin. Mix well and cook for about 1 minute.

Step 8: Pour the spinach puree into the pan and mix thoroughly.

Step 9: Simmer the spinach mixture on low heat for about 5 minutes, stirring occasionally.

Step 10: Add salt, sugar, and a pinch of nutmeg. Mix well.

Step 11: Gently add the cooked paneer cubes. Stir to combine without breaking the paneer.

Step 12: Reduce heat to low and simmer for 3-4 minutes. Add cream just before serving.

Step 13: Garnish with fresh coriander and serve hot with rice or Indian breads.

TIPS AND VARIATIONS

- Use fresh spinach for the best flavor. If using frozen spinach, thaw and squeeze out excess water before blanching.[file:1]
- Do not overcook the spinach; it will lose its vibrant green color.[file:1]
- Paneer can be fried or grilled before adding to the curry for extra texture.[file:1]
- For a creamier version, add an additional 2 tablespoons of heavy cream or milk.[file:1]
- This dish is best served hot with garlic naan or steamed rice.[file:1]
- Leftover Palak Paneer can be refrigerated for up to 4 days.[file:1]

3. SAMBAR

Region: South India | Cuisine Type: Vegetarian

RECIPE INFORMATION

Servings: 4 servings

Preparation Time: 20 minutes

Cooking Time: 35 minutes

Total Time: 55 minutes

Difficulty Level: Intermediate

Spice Level: Medium to Hot

INGREDIENTS (For 4 servings)

- 2 cups mixed vegetables (carrot, beans, potatoes), cubed
- 1/2 cup pigeon peas (arhar/toor dal), soaked
- 2 medium tomatoes, chopped
- 2 tablespoons oil
- 1 teaspoon mustard seeds
- 1 teaspoon cumin seeds
- 2-3 dried red chilies
- 1/2 teaspoon turmeric powder
- 1 teaspoon sambar powder
- 6-8 curry leaves
- Salt to taste
- 3 cups water
- 2 tablespoons tamarind paste
- Fresh coriander, chopped

COOKING INSTRUCTIONS

Step 1: Soak pigeon peas (dal) in water for 15-20 minutes. Drain and set aside.

Step 2: Peel and chop vegetables into uniform pieces for even cooking.

Step 3: Heat 2 tablespoons of oil in a heavy-bottomed pan over medium heat.

Step 4: Add mustard seeds and let them splutter. Add cumin seeds and dried red chilies. Let them crackle for about 30 seconds.

Step 5: Add curry leaves and fry for 10-15 seconds until fragrant.

Step 6: Add chopped vegetables and cook for about 5 minutes, stirring occasionally.

Step 7: Add drained pigeon peas and stir to combine.

Step 8: Add turmeric powder and mix well.

Step 9: Add chopped tomatoes and cook until they are fully cooked and soft (about 5 minutes).

Step 10: Pour 3 cups of water and bring to a boil. Cook on medium heat until dal and vegetables

are soft (about 15 minutes).

Step 11: Add tamarind paste and sambar powder. Stir well to combine.

Step 12: Simmer for another 5 minutes to allow flavors to meld.

Step 13: Taste and adjust salt as needed. The sambar should have a tangy-spicy flavor.

Step 14: Garnish with fresh coriander and serve hot with rice or idli.

TIPS AND VARIATIONS

- Sambar powder is essential and can be purchased from Indian grocery stores or made at home by roasting and grinding dried red chilies, cumin, coriander, and other spices.[file:1]
- Tamarind paste provides the characteristic tangy flavor. Adjust quantity based on preference.[file:1]
- You can add okra, drumstick pieces, or eggplant as variations.[file:1]
- Sambar is traditionally served with dosa, idli, or steamed rice.[file:1]
- Store in the refrigerator for up to 4 days.[file:1]

4. DOSA

Region: South India | Cuisine Type: Vegetarian

RECIPE INFORMATION

Servings: 4 servings (8 dosas)

Preparation Time: 30 minutes (plus soaking overnight)

Cooking Time: 20 minutes

Total Time: 8 hours 50 minutes

Difficulty Level: Intermediate

Spice Level: Mild

INGREDIENTS (For 8 dosas)

For the Batter

- 2 cups rice grains
- 3/4 cup urad dal (split black gram)
- 1/2 teaspoon fenugreek (methi) seeds
- Salt to taste
- Water as needed
- Oil for cooking

For Potato Filling

- 3 medium potatoes, boiled and diced
- 1 medium onion, finely chopped
- 2-3 green chilies, chopped
- 1 tablespoon oil
- 1 teaspoon mustard seeds
- 1/4 teaspoon turmeric powder
- Salt to taste
- Curry leaves, chopped

COOKING INSTRUCTIONS

For the Batter:

Step 1: Soak rice grains, urad dal, and fenugreek seeds separately in water for 8 hours or overnight.

Step 2: Drain the soaked rice, urad dal, and fenugreek seeds.

Step 3: Blend the soaked ingredients in a wet grinder with minimal water to create a smooth, thick batter. The batter should be smooth but thick.

Step 4: Transfer to a bowl and let it ferment at room temperature for 8 hours or overnight until light and fluffy.

Step 5: Add salt and mix well just before use. The batter should be pourable but thick.

For the Potato Filling:

Step 1: Boil and dice potatoes into small pieces.

Step 2: Heat 1 tablespoon of oil in a pan. Add mustard seeds and let them splutter.

Step 3: Add curry leaves and green chilies. Cook for 30 seconds.

Step 4: Add diced potatoes and turmeric powder. Mix well.

Step 5: Add chopped onions and salt. Sauté until onions are soft (about 5 minutes). Set aside.

Making the Dosa:

Step 1: Heat a non-stick dosa pan or crepe pan over high heat until very hot.

Step 2: Lightly oil the pan with a cloth or brush.

Step 3: Pour 1/4 cup batter onto the pan and spread thinly and evenly using the back of a ladle in circular motions.

Step 4: Cook on high heat for about 1-2 minutes until the bottom is crispy and light golden brown.

Step 5: Add a spoonful of potato filling in the center and fold the dosa in half.

Step 6: Cook for another 30 seconds until the edges are crispy.

Step 7: Transfer to a serving plate. Serve hot with chutney and sambar.

TIPS AND VARIATIONS

- Dosa batter requires fermentation for the characteristic light and crispy texture. Ensure proper fermentation.[file:1]
- The pan must be very hot for crispy dosas. Test by sprinkling water; it should sizzle immediately.[file:1]
- If batter is too thick, add a little water. If too thin, it will not spread properly.[file:1]
- Serve dosa immediately after cooking while it is crispy.[file:1]
- Plain dosa without filling is also popular and equally delicious.[file:1]
- Store leftover fermented batter in the refrigerator for up to 4 days.[file:1]

5. BIRYANI

Region: North India | Cuisine Type: Non-Vegetarian (Chicken Biryani)

RECIPE INFORMATION

Servings: 4 servings

Preparation Time: 30 minutes

Cooking Time: 45 minutes

Total Time: 1 hour 15 minutes

Difficulty Level: Intermediate to Advanced

Spice Level: Medium

INGREDIENTS (For 4 servings)

- 2 cups basmati rice, soaked for 30 minutes
- 600g chicken, cut into medium pieces
- 1 cup yogurt
- 3 medium onions, sliced
- 4 tablespoons ghee or oil
- 1 tablespoon ginger-garlic paste
- 2 green chilies, slit
- 1 tablespoon yogurt
- 1 teaspoon red chili powder
- 1 teaspoon garam masala powder
- 1 teaspoon cumin powder
- 1/2 teaspoon turmeric powder
- Salt to taste
- 2 bay leaves
- 4-5 green cardamom pods

- 2-3 black cardamom pods
- 4-5 cloves
- 1-inch piece cinnamon stick
- 1 teaspoon black cumin (shah jeera)
- Water as needed
- Fresh mint and coriander for garnish
- 2 tablespoons fried onions (optional)

COOKING INSTRUCTIONS

Step 1: Marinate chicken with 1 cup yogurt, ginger-garlic paste, green chilies, red chili powder, garam masala, and salt for at least 15 minutes.

Step 2: Heat 3 tablespoons ghee in a pan and fry the sliced onions until golden brown and crispy. Remove with a slotted spoon and set aside.

Step 3: In the same ghee, add the marinated chicken and cook on high heat for 8-10 minutes until 70% cooked. Do not fully cook the chicken.

Step 4: In a separate large pot, boil water with bay leaves, cardamom, cloves, cinnamon, and black cumin. This infused water is crucial for flavor.

Step 5: Add soaked rice to the boiling water along with salt. Cook until 70% done (rice should still be firm).

Step 6: Drain the rice immediately using a colander.

Step 7: Layer the biryani: In a heavy-bottomed pot (preferably clay or cast iron), spread half the partially cooked rice as the base.

Step 8: Layer all the cooked chicken on top of the rice.

Step 9: Layer the remaining rice on top of the chicken.

Step 10: Sprinkle fried onions on top, followed by fresh mint and coriander leaves.

Step 11: Dot with the remaining 1 tablespoon of ghee.

Step 12: Cover the pot with aluminum foil and then place a tight-fitting lid on top. This is called Dum Pukht - steam cooking.

Step 13: Place the covered pot on medium heat for about 3-4 minutes until steam forms (you should hear a slight sizzle).

Step 14: Reduce heat to low and cook for 25-30 minutes. The rice will cook in the steam created by the moisture from the chicken and rice.

Step 15: Turn off heat and let it rest for 5 minutes without opening the lid.

Step 16: Gently mix the biryani with a fork, being careful not to break the rice grains.

Step 17: Garnish with fresh mint, coriander, fried onions, and serve hot.

TIPS AND VARIATIONS

- The key to perfect biryani is Dum Pukht (steam cooking). Ensure the lid is tight and properly sealed.[file:1]
- Use long-grain basmati rice for the best results.[file:1]
- Both rice and chicken should be cooked only 70%. The remaining cooking happens through steam.[file:1]

- The whole spices should not be eaten; remove them while serving or warn guests.[file:1]
- For vegetarian biryani, replace chicken with paneer and vegetables.[file:1]
- For mutton biryani, use goat meat and increase cooking time by 10 minutes.[file:1]
- Biryani is traditionally served with raita (yogurt), pickle, and salad.[file:1]
- Leftover biryani can be refrigerated and reheated by sprinkling water and covering for a few minutes.[file:1]

6. CHANA MASALA

Region: North India | Cuisine Type: Vegetarian

RECIPE INFORMATION

Servings: 4 servings

Preparation Time: 15 minutes

Cooking Time: 25 minutes

Total Time: 40 minutes

Difficulty Level: Easy

Spice Level: Medium to Hot

INGREDIENTS (For 4 servings)

- 2 cans (400g each) chickpeas (canned or boiled dried chickpeas)
- 2 tablespoons oil
- 1 medium onion, finely chopped
- 1 tablespoon ginger-garlic paste
- 2 medium tomatoes, finely chopped
- 1 teaspoon cumin seeds
- 1/2 teaspoon turmeric powder
- 1 teaspoon red chili powder
- 1 teaspoon ground coriander
- 1 teaspoon chaat masala powder
- 1 teaspoon garam masala powder
- 1/2 cup water
- Salt to taste
- 2 tablespoons fresh coriander, chopped
- 1 green chili, chopped
- 1 lemon, cut into wedges

COOKING INSTRUCTIONS

- Step 1: Drain and rinse the canned chickpeas or use boiled dried chickpeas.
- Step 2: Heat 2 tablespoons of oil in a pan over medium heat.
- Step 3: Add cumin seeds and let them splutter for about 30 seconds.
- Step 4: Add chopped onions and cook until they turn golden brown (about 4-5 minutes).
- Step 5: Add ginger-garlic paste and cook for about 1 minute until fragrant.
- Step 6: Add chopped tomatoes and cook until they are fully softened and oil separates from the mixture (about 5-7 minutes).
- Step 7: Add turmeric powder, red chili powder, and ground coriander. Mix well.
- Step 8: Add the drained chickpeas and stir to coat with the spice mixture.
- Step 9: Add 1/2 cup of water and bring to a simmer.
- Step 10: Add chaat masala and garam masala powder. Mix well.
- Step 11: Simmer for about 10 minutes, allowing flavors to meld and the gravy to thicken slightly.
- Step 12: Taste and adjust salt as needed. The dish should have a tangy spicy flavor.
- Step 13: Add lemon juice to taste and stir well.
- Step 14: Garnish with fresh coriander and green chili.
- Step 15: Serve hot with bhature, puri, or plain rice.

TIPS AND VARIATIONS

- Chaat masala is essential for the authentic tangy flavor. It is available in Indian grocery stores.[file:1]
- For a more authentic experience, use boiled dried chickpeas instead of canned if time permits.[file:1]
- Add 1 tablespoon of pomegranate seeds (anardana powder) for extra tanginess.[file:1]
- For a healthier version, use fewer chickpeas and add more vegetables like peppers or carrots.[file:1]
- This dish is best served hot with Indian breads like bhature or puri.[file:1]
- Chana Masala pairs well with rice as well.[file:1]
- Store in the refrigerator for up to 5 days.[file:1]
- For a spicier version, increase the red chili powder by 1/2 teaspoon.[file:1]

7. ROGAN JOSH

Region: Kashmir / North India | Cuisine Type: Non-Vegetarian

RECIPE INFORMATION

Servings: 4 servings

Preparation Time: 20 minutes

Cooking Time: 50 minutes

Total Time: 1 hour 10 minutes

Difficulty Level: Intermediate

Spice Level: Medium

INGREDIENTS (For 4 servings)

- 700g mutton or goat, cut into medium pieces
- 3 tablespoons mustard oil or ghee
- 1 cup yogurt, whisked
- 2 tablespoons ginger paste
- 1 teaspoon garlic paste
- 2 teaspoons Kashmiri red chili powder
- 1 teaspoon fennel powder
- 1/2 teaspoon dry ginger powder
- 1 teaspoon garam masala powder
- 2 bay leaves
- 4 green cardamom pods
- 4 cloves
- 1-inch cinnamon stick
- Salt to taste
- 2 to 2 1/2 cups water
- Fresh coriander for garnish (optional)

COOKING INSTRUCTIONS

Step 1: Heat mustard oil in a heavy-bottomed pot until it reaches smoking point, then lower the heat slightly.

Step 2: Add bay leaves, cardamom, cloves, and cinnamon. Sauté for 20-30 seconds until aromatic.

Step 3: Add the mutton pieces and sear on medium-high heat for 6-8 minutes until lightly browned.

Step 4: Reduce heat to low and add ginger paste and garlic paste. Cook for 1 minute.

Step 5: Add whisked yogurt gradually, stirring continuously to prevent curdling.

Step 6: Add Kashmiri red chili powder, fennel powder, dry ginger powder, garam masala, and salt. Mix well.

Step 7: Pour in water and bring to a gentle boil.

Step 8: Cover and cook on low heat for 35-40 minutes, or until the meat becomes tender. Stir occasionally.

Step 9: Adjust salt and simmer uncovered for 5 minutes if a thicker gravy is desired.

Step 10: Garnish lightly and serve hot with rice, naan, or roti.

TIPS AND VARIATIONS

- Rogan Josh is associated with Kashmiri cuisine and is traditionally made with red meat, usually lamb, mutton, or goat.[page:1]
- Traditional versions get color from Kashmiri chilies or coloring ingredients such as alkanet rather than tomato-heavy gravy.[page:1]
- Yogurt helps create body in the sauce; add it slowly over low heat to reduce splitting. [page:1]
- For a richer finish, rest the curry 10 minutes before serving so the flavors settle.

8. DAL MAKHNI

Region: Punjab / North India | Cuisine Type: Vegetarian

RECIPE INFORMATION

Servings: 4 servings

Preparation Time: 15 minutes (plus soaking overnight)

Cooking Time: 45 minutes

Total Time: 1 hour

Difficulty Level: Intermediate

Spice Level: Mild to Medium

INGREDIENTS (For 4 servings)

- 1 cup whole urad dal (black gram)
- 1/4 cup rajma (kidney beans)
- 3 tablespoons butter
- 1 tablespoon oil or ghee
- 1 medium onion, finely chopped
- 1 tablespoon ginger-garlic paste
- 1 cup tomato puree
- 1/2 teaspoon turmeric powder
- 1 teaspoon red chili powder
- 1 teaspoon garam masala powder
- 1 teaspoon cumin seeds
- 1 bay leaf
- 1/4 cup cream
- Salt to taste
- 3 to 4 cups water
- 1 teaspoon kasuri methi, crushed

- Fresh coriander for garnish

COOKING INSTRUCTIONS

Step 1: Wash and soak urad dal and rajma overnight in enough water.

Step 2: Drain, add fresh water, and pressure-cook until both are soft and creamy.

Step 3: Heat oil and 1 tablespoon butter in a pan. Add cumin seeds and bay leaf. Let them splutter.

Step 4: Add onions and sauté until golden brown.

Step 5: Add ginger-garlic paste and cook for 1 minute until fragrant.

Step 6: Add tomato puree, turmeric, red chili powder, garam masala, and salt. Cook until the oil begins to separate.

Step 7: Add the cooked dal and rajma with some cooking liquid. Mix well.

Step 8: Simmer on low heat for 20-25 minutes, stirring occasionally and lightly mashing some lentils for a creamy texture.

Step 9: Add the remaining butter, crushed kasuri methi, and cream. Stir well.

Step 10: Simmer for another 5 minutes and serve hot with naan or jeera rice.

TIPS AND VARIATIONS

- Dal Makhni originated in the Punjab region and is built around urad dal, rajma, butter, and cream.[page:2]
- The creamy texture improves when the lentils simmer slowly and some of them are mashed into the sauce.[page:2]
- A small final garnish of cream or yogurt is common before serving.[page:2]
- For a lighter version, reduce cream and increase the final simmering time for natural thickness.

9. PANEER TIKKA

Region: North India | Cuisine Type: Vegetarian

RECIPE INFORMATION

Servings: 4 servings

Preparation Time: 25 minutes

Cooking Time: 20 minutes

Total Time: 45 minutes

Difficulty Level: Easy to Intermediate

Spice Level: Medium

INGREDIENTS (For 4 servings)

- 300g paneer, cut into cubes
- 1 medium onion, cut into petals
- 1 medium capsicum, cut into squares
- 1/2 cup thick yogurt
- 1 tablespoon ginger-garlic paste
- 1 teaspoon red chili powder
- 1/2 teaspoon turmeric powder
- 1 teaspoon garam masala powder
- 1 teaspoon roasted cumin powder
- 1 teaspoon coriander powder
- 1 tablespoon gram flour (besan)
- 1 tablespoon lemon juice
- 1 tablespoon mustard oil
- Salt to taste
- Butter or oil for basting
- Chaat masala for sprinkling

COOKING INSTRUCTIONS

Step 1: In a bowl, mix yogurt, ginger-garlic paste, red chili powder, turmeric, garam masala, cumin powder, coriander powder, gram flour, lemon juice, mustard oil, and salt to form a thick marinade.

Step 2: Add paneer, onion, and capsicum. Toss gently until evenly coated.

Step 3: Marinate for at least 20 minutes.

Step 4: Thread paneer and vegetables alternately onto skewers.

Step 5: Arrange on a greased tray and grill or bake in a preheated oven at 220°C for 12-15 minutes, turning once midway.

Step 6: Baste lightly with butter or oil in the last few minutes for a slight char.

Step 7: Sprinkle with chaat masala and serve hot with mint chutney.

TIPS AND VARIATIONS

- Thick yogurt and besan help the marinade cling better to paneer and vegetables.[web:4]
- Paneer Tikka is commonly served with naan, roti, or rice-based sides in restaurant-style meals.[web:4]
- For stovetop cooking, use a grill pan or tawa on medium-high heat until light char marks appear.
- Avoid overcooking paneer, because it can become chewy.

10. NAAN

Region: North India | Cuisine Type: Bread

RECIPE INFORMATION

Servings: 8 naans

Preparation Time: 20 minutes (plus resting time)

Cooking Time: 20 minutes

Total Time: 1 hour 40 minutes

Difficulty Level: Intermediate

Spice Level: Mild

INGREDIENTS (For 8 naans)

- 3 cups all-purpose flour
- 1 teaspoon sugar
- 1 teaspoon salt
- 1 teaspoon baking powder
- 1/2 teaspoon baking soda
- 3 tablespoons yogurt
- 2 tablespoons oil
- 3/4 to 1 cup warm water
- Butter for brushing
- 2 tablespoons chopped coriander or minced garlic (optional)

COOKING INSTRUCTIONS

Step 1: In a large bowl, combine flour, sugar, salt, baking powder, and baking soda.

Step 2: Add yogurt and oil. Mix well.

Step 3: Add warm water gradually and knead into a soft dough.

Step 4: Cover and rest the dough for 1 hour.

Step 5: Divide dough into equal balls. Roll each ball into an oval or teardrop shape.

Step 6: Heat a tawa or heavy skillet on high heat.

Step 7: Place the naan on the hot surface and cook until bubbles appear. Flip and cook the other side, or expose the top to direct flame if suitable.

Step 8: Brush with butter and garnish with garlic or coriander if desired. Serve hot.

TIPS AND VARIATIONS

- Yogurt helps keep naan soft and slightly chewy.
- Garlic naan can be made by pressing minced garlic and coriander onto the rolled dough before cooking.
- For extra softness, keep the cooked naan covered in a cloth-lined container.

- Naan pairs well with creamy curries such as Butter Chicken and Dal Makhni.[file:1][page:2]

11. ROTI

Region: North India | Cuisine Type: Bread

RECIPE INFORMATION

Servings: 8 rotis

Preparation Time: 15 minutes (plus resting time)

Cooking Time: 20 minutes

Total Time: 45 minutes

Difficulty Level: Easy

Spice Level: Mild

INGREDIENTS (For 8 rotis)

- 2 cups whole wheat flour
- 3/4 cup warm water, approximately
- 1/2 teaspoon salt (optional)
- 1 teaspoon oil or ghee (optional)
- Extra flour for dusting
- Ghee for brushing (optional)

COOKING INSTRUCTIONS

Step 1: Combine whole wheat flour and salt in a bowl.

Step 2: Add warm water gradually and knead into a soft, smooth dough.

Step 3: Rest the dough for 20 minutes covered with a damp cloth.

Step 4: Divide into small balls and roll each into a thin round disc using dry flour.

Step 5: Heat a tawa over medium-high heat.

Step 6: Place one rolled roti on the hot tawa and cook until bubbles form.

Step 7: Flip and cook the second side; press lightly until brown spots appear.

Step 8: Optionally puff directly over flame for a few seconds. Brush with ghee and serve hot.

TIPS AND VARIATIONS

- Use soft dough for tender rotis.
- Do not add too much dry flour while rolling, or the roti may turn dry.
- Rotis are an everyday bread that pair well with lentils, vegetable curries, and dry sabzis.
- Keep cooked rotis wrapped in a cloth to retain softness.

12. IDLI

Region: South India | Cuisine Type: Vegetarian

RECIPE INFORMATION

Servings: 4 servings (12-14 idlis)

Preparation Time: 30 minutes (plus soaking and fermentation)

Cooking Time: 15 minutes

Total Time: 8 hours 45 minutes

Difficulty Level: Intermediate

Spice Level: Mild

INGREDIENTS (For 12-14 idlis)

- 2 cups idli rice
- 1 cup urad dal
- 1/2 teaspoon fenugreek seeds
- Salt to taste
- Water as needed
- Oil for greasing molds

COOKING INSTRUCTIONS

Step 1: Wash rice, urad dal, and fenugreek seeds separately. Soak them for 6-8 hours.

Step 2: Grind urad dal to a light, fluffy batter using minimal water. Grind rice to a slightly grainy batter.

Step 3: Combine both batters in a large bowl. Add salt lightly if desired after fermentation.

Step 4: Ferment overnight or until the batter rises and becomes airy.

Step 5: Grease idli molds and pour batter into each cavity.

Step 6: Steam for 10-12 minutes until cooked through.

Step 7: Rest for 2 minutes, unmold gently, and serve hot with chutney or sambar.

TIPS AND VARIATIONS

- Idli depends on proper fermentation for soft texture, similar to dosa batter preparation.
[file:1]
- Use a slightly coarse rice grind and a fluffy urad dal grind for better structure.
- Wet a spoon before unmolding to prevent sticking.
- Leftover idlis can be used in idli fry or soaked in rasam for serving.

13. RASAM

Region: South India | Cuisine Type: Vegetarian

RECIPE INFORMATION

Servings: 4 servings

Preparation Time: 15 minutes

Cooking Time: 20 minutes

Total Time: 35 minutes

Difficulty Level: Easy to Intermediate

Spice Level: Medium

INGREDIENTS (For 4 servings)

- 2 medium tomatoes, chopped
- 2 tablespoons tamarind pulp
- 2 tablespoons cooked toor dal
- 1 teaspoon rasam powder
- 1/4 teaspoon turmeric powder
- 1/2 teaspoon black pepper powder
- 1/2 teaspoon cumin powder
- 3 cups water
- Salt to taste
- 1 teaspoon ghee
- 1/2 teaspoon mustard seeds
- 1 dried red chili
- 6-8 curry leaves
- Pinch of asafoetida
- Fresh coriander for garnish

COOKING INSTRUCTIONS

Step 1: In a pot, combine chopped tomatoes, tamarind pulp, turmeric, salt, and water. Bring to a boil.

Step 2: Add rasam powder, black pepper, cumin powder, and cooked toor dal.

Step 3: Simmer for 8-10 minutes until the tomatoes soften and the flavors blend.

Step 4: In a small pan, heat ghee and add mustard seeds. Let them splutter.

Step 5: Add dried red chili, asafoetida, and curry leaves. Fry briefly.

Step 6: Pour the tempering into the rasam and switch off the heat.

Step 7: Garnish with coriander and serve hot.

TIPS AND VARIATIONS

- Rasam commonly combines tamarind, tomatoes, spices, and a final tempering with mustard seeds and curry leaves.[web:10]
- Some versions include cooked toor dal for body, while others stay lighter and more broth-like.[web:10]
- Avoid prolonged boiling after tempering to preserve aroma.
- Serve with rice, idli, or as a light soup.

14. COCONUT CURRY

Region: South India | Cuisine Type: Vegetarian

RECIPE INFORMATION

Servings: 4 servings

Preparation Time: 15 minutes

Cooking Time: 25 minutes

Total Time: 40 minutes

Difficulty Level: Easy

Spice Level: Mild to Medium

INGREDIENTS (For 4 servings)

- 2 cups mixed vegetables (carrot, beans, peas, or potato)
- 1 cup coconut milk
- 1 medium onion, sliced
- 1 medium tomato, chopped
- 1 tablespoon oil or coconut oil
- 1 teaspoon mustard seeds
- 1/2 teaspoon cumin seeds
- 1-2 green chilies, slit
- 8-10 curry leaves
- 1/2 teaspoon turmeric powder
- 1 teaspoon coriander powder
- 1/2 teaspoon garam masala or curry powder
- Salt to taste
- 1 cup water
- Fresh coriander for garnish

COOKING INSTRUCTIONS

Step 1: Heat oil in a pan. Add mustard seeds and cumin seeds. Let them splutter.

Step 2: Add curry leaves, green chilies, and sliced onions. Sauté until translucent.

Step 3: Add tomatoes and cook until soft.

Step 4: Add turmeric, coriander powder, and salt. Mix well.

Step 5: Add mixed vegetables and water. Cover and cook until vegetables are tender.

Step 6: Pour in coconut milk and simmer gently for 5-7 minutes. Do not boil vigorously.

Step 7: Add garam masala or curry powder, mix, garnish, and serve hot with rice or appam.

TIPS AND VARIATIONS

- Coconut-based South Indian curries often use a tempered base with mustard seeds, curry leaves, and gentle simmering after coconut is added.[web:13]
- Keep the flame low after adding coconut milk to reduce the chance of splitting.[web:13]
- Add chickpeas or paneer for extra protein.
- For a Kerala-style note, add a little black pepper and coconut oil at the finish.

15. ALOO GOBI

Region: North India | Cuisine Type: Vegetarian

RECIPE INFORMATION

Servings: 4 servings

Preparation Time: 15 minutes

Cooking Time: 25 minutes

Total Time: 40 minutes

Difficulty Level: Easy

Spice Level: Mild to Medium

INGREDIENTS (For 4 servings)

- 2 cups cauliflower florets
- 2 medium potatoes, cubed
- 2 tablespoons oil
- 1 teaspoon cumin seeds
- 1 medium onion, chopped
- 1 medium tomato, chopped
- 1 tablespoon ginger-garlic paste
- 1/2 teaspoon turmeric powder
- 1 teaspoon coriander powder
- 1/2 teaspoon red chili powder

- 1/2 teaspoon garam masala powder
- Salt to taste
- 2 tablespoons fresh coriander, chopped
- 1 green chili, chopped (optional)

COOKING INSTRUCTIONS

Step 1: Heat oil in a pan and add cumin seeds. Let them splutter.

Step 2: Add onions and sauté until golden.

Step 3: Add ginger-garlic paste and cook for 1 minute.

Step 4: Add tomatoes and cook until soft.

Step 5: Stir in turmeric, coriander powder, red chili powder, and salt.

Step 6: Add potatoes and cauliflower. Mix well to coat with spices.

Step 7: Cover and cook on low heat for 15-18 minutes, stirring occasionally, until vegetables are tender.

Step 8: Sprinkle garam masala and fresh coriander before serving.

TIPS AND VARIATIONS

- Do not over-stir once cauliflower softens, or the dish can turn mushy.
- For a drier sabzi, cook uncovered for the last few minutes.
- Peas can be added for extra sweetness and color.
- Serve with roti, paratha, or dal-rice.

16. PANEER BIRYANI

Region: North India | Cuisine Type: Vegetarian

RECIPE INFORMATION

Servings: 4 servings

Preparation Time: 30 minutes

Cooking Time: 40 minutes

Total Time: 1 hour 10 minutes

Difficulty Level: Intermediate

Spice Level: Medium

INGREDIENTS (For 4 servings)

- 2 cups basmati rice, soaked for 30 minutes
- 300g paneer, cubed
- 1/2 cup yogurt
- 2 medium onions, sliced
- 2 tablespoons ghee or oil

- 1 tablespoon ginger-garlic paste
- 2 green chilies, slit
- 1 teaspoon red chili powder
- 1 teaspoon garam masala powder
- 1/2 teaspoon turmeric powder
- 1 teaspoon cumin powder
- Salt to taste
- 1 bay leaf
- 4 green cardamom pods
- 4 cloves
- 1-inch cinnamon stick
- 2 tablespoons mint leaves
- 2 tablespoons coriander leaves
- 2 tablespoons fried onions

COOKING INSTRUCTIONS

Step 1: Marinate paneer with yogurt, ginger-garlic paste, chili powder, turmeric, garam masala, cumin powder, and salt for 15 minutes.

Step 2: Fry sliced onions until golden and set aside.

Step 3: Cook the marinated paneer gently for 3-4 minutes without breaking the cubes.

Step 4: Boil water with bay leaf, cardamom, cloves, and cinnamon. Add soaked rice and cook until 70% done. Drain.

Step 5: In a heavy-bottomed pot, spread a layer of rice, then paneer mixture, then another layer of rice.

Step 6: Top with fried onions, mint, coriander, and a little ghee.

Step 7: Cover tightly and cook on low heat for 20-25 minutes.

Step 8: Rest for 5 minutes and fluff gently before serving.

TIPS AND VARIATIONS

- This version follows the same layered dum method used in the biryani recipe from the source document, replacing chicken with paneer.[file:1]
- Keep paneer only lightly cooked before dum so it stays soft.[file:1]
- Add vegetables such as carrots, beans, or peas for a fuller vegetarian biryani.
- Serve with raita, pickle, and salad, as suggested for biryani in the source file.[file:1]

17. PILAF

Region: Indian Rice Dish | Cuisine Type: Vegetarian

RECIPE INFORMATION

Servings: 4 servings

Preparation Time: 15 minutes

Cooking Time: 25 minutes

Total Time: 40 minutes

Difficulty Level: Easy

Spice Level: Mild

INGREDIENTS (For 4 servings)

- 2 cups basmati rice
- 1 small onion, sliced
- 2 tablespoons ghee or oil
- 1 bay leaf
- 4 cloves
- 2 green cardamom pods
- 1 small cinnamon stick
- 1/2 cup peas
- 1/2 cup diced carrots
- 4 cups water
- Salt to taste
- 2 tablespoons coriander leaves

COOKING INSTRUCTIONS

Step 1: Wash rice until the water runs clear. Soak for 20 minutes and drain.

Step 2: Heat ghee in a pot. Add bay leaf, cloves, cardamom, and cinnamon. Sauté briefly.

Step 3: Add sliced onion and cook until light golden.

Step 4: Add peas and carrots. Stir for 2 minutes.

Step 5: Add drained rice and sauté gently for 1 minute.

Step 6: Add water and salt. Bring to a boil.

Step 7: Cover and cook on low heat until the rice is fluffy and fully cooked.

Step 8: Rest for 5 minutes, fluff with a fork, garnish, and serve.

TIPS AND VARIATIONS

- Pilaf relies on fragrant whole spices and separate rice grains rather than heavy gravy.
- For a richer flavor, replace part of the water with light vegetable stock.
- Cashews and raisins can be added for a festive version.
- This dish works well alongside curries, kebabs, or yogurt-based sides.

18. FRIED RICE

Region: Indo-Chinese / Indian Rice Dish | Cuisine Type: Vegetarian

RECIPE INFORMATION

Servings: 4 servings

Preparation Time: 15 minutes

Cooking Time: 15 minutes

Total Time: 30 minutes

Difficulty Level: Easy

Spice Level: Mild to Medium

INGREDIENTS (For 4 servings)

- 3 cups cooked rice, cooled
- 2 tablespoons oil
- 1 tablespoon finely chopped garlic
- 1 small onion, sliced
- 1/2 cup cabbage, shredded
- 1/2 cup carrot, finely chopped
- 1/4 cup capsicum, chopped
- 2 tablespoons spring onion, chopped
- 1 teaspoon soy sauce
- 1/2 teaspoon black pepper
- Salt to taste
- 1 teaspoon vinegar (optional)

COOKING INSTRUCTIONS

Step 1: Heat oil in a wok or broad pan on high heat.

Step 2: Add garlic and onion. Stir-fry for 30-40 seconds.

Step 3: Add cabbage, carrot, and capsicum. Stir-fry on high heat for 2-3 minutes.

Step 4: Add cooled rice and toss gently without breaking the grains.

Step 5: Add soy sauce, black pepper, salt, and vinegar if using. Mix well on high heat.

Step 6: Add spring onion and cook for another minute.

Step 7: Serve hot.

TIPS AND VARIATIONS

- Use cooled rice so the grains remain separate during stir-frying.
- High heat is important for proper fried rice texture.
- Add paneer, egg, or mixed vegetables based on preference.
- Keep seasonings light so the rice does not become soggy.

19. FISH CURRY

Region: Indian Coastal Cuisine | Cuisine Type: Seafood

RECIPE INFORMATION

Servings: 4 servings

Preparation Time: 20 minutes

Cooking Time: 25 minutes

Total Time: 45 minutes

Difficulty Level: Intermediate

Spice Level: Medium

INGREDIENTS (For 4 servings)

- 500g firm fish pieces
- 2 tablespoons oil
- 1 medium onion, finely chopped
- 1 medium tomato, chopped
- 1 tablespoon ginger-garlic paste
- 1/2 teaspoon turmeric powder
- 1 teaspoon red chili powder
- 1 teaspoon coriander powder
- 1/2 teaspoon cumin powder
- 2 tablespoons tamarind pulp or 1/2 cup coconut milk
- Salt to taste
- 1 1/2 cups water
- 6-8 curry leaves
- Fresh coriander for garnish

COOKING INSTRUCTIONS

Step 1: Clean the fish and rub lightly with salt and turmeric. Set aside for 10 minutes.
Step 2: Heat oil in a pan and sauté onions until golden.
Step 3: Add ginger-garlic paste and cook for 1 minute.
Step 4: Add tomatoes and cook until soft.
Step 5: Add turmeric, chili powder, coriander powder, cumin powder, and salt. Mix well.
Step 6: Pour in water and tamarind pulp or coconut milk. Bring to a simmer.
Step 7: Add curry leaves and fish pieces. Cook gently for 8-10 minutes until the fish is just done.
Step 8: Garnish and serve hot with rice.

TIPS AND VARIATIONS

- Do not stir aggressively after adding fish, because delicate pieces can break.
- Tamarind creates a tangier curry, while coconut milk gives a softer and richer style.
- Marinate with a little chili and lemon for extra flavor before cooking.
- Rest the curry for a few minutes before serving so the fish absorbs the gravy.

20. PRAWN MASALA

Region: Indian Coastal Cuisine | Cuisine Type: Seafood

RECIPE INFORMATION

Servings: 4 servings

Preparation Time: 20 minutes

Cooking Time: 20 minutes

Total Time: 40 minutes

Difficulty Level: Easy to Intermediate

Spice Level: Medium to Hot

INGREDIENTS (For 4 servings)

- 500g prawns, cleaned and deveined
- 2 tablespoons oil
- 1 medium onion, finely chopped
- 1 medium tomato, finely chopped
- 1 tablespoon ginger-garlic paste
- 1/2 teaspoon turmeric powder
- 1 teaspoon red chili powder
- 1 teaspoon coriander powder
- 1/2 teaspoon garam masala powder
- Salt to taste

- 1 green chili, chopped
- 8 curry leaves
- 2 tablespoons coriander leaves
- 1 teaspoon lemon juice

COOKING INSTRUCTIONS

Step 1: Clean prawns and marinate with turmeric, salt, and a little lemon juice for 10 minutes.

Step 2: Heat oil in a pan and cook onions until golden.

Step 3: Add ginger-garlic paste and green chili. Cook for 1 minute.

Step 4: Add tomatoes and cook until softened.

Step 5: Add red chili powder, coriander powder, garam masala, and salt. Cook until the masala thickens.

Step 6: Add prawns and curry leaves. Stir gently.

Step 7: Cook for 4-6 minutes until the prawns turn pink and are just cooked through.

Step 8: Finish with coriander leaves and serve hot with rice or roti.

TIPS AND VARIATIONS

- Prawns cook quickly; overcooking makes them rubbery.
- Curry leaves and ginger-garlic paste give the masala a stronger coastal flavor profile.
- A splash of coconut milk can be added for a softer gravy style.
- This dish also works as a dry masala if cooked until the moisture reduces.